

First Flights: Choose Your Aircraft

Cleared For Take-Off Academy · AI for Grown-Ups

The Tool Hangar selector. Pick the right aircraft, then go to its lesson.

What this is. Not a course, and not twenty things to learn. This is the page you stand in front of when you think, “there is probably an AI for this, but which one?” Tell it the job you want done, and it points you at the right aircraft and the lesson that teaches it.

How to use it. Three steps. Find your job in Step one. Note the tool it sends you to. Go and fly that tool’s First Flight lesson. That is the whole drill. You are not meant to read this cover to cover, and you are certainly not meant to try all twenty. Most people need three.

The rule that never changes. Whichever aircraft you roll out, you are still the Captain. Brief, steer, verify, decide. The never-share list from Module 1 applies in every cockpit, and the rule of two from Module 5 retires for no tool. Learn the job, and the names can do whatever they like.

Step one: what is the job?

Find the row that matches what you actually want to do, then head for the aircraft named. The full card and lesson for each tool are further down.

If you want to...	Start with...	Hangar
Write, reply, explain, plan, or think something through	ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or Copilot	Chat assistants
Research with sources you can click and check	Perplexity	Research
Make sense of your own documents	NotebookLM	Research
Make a picture from a description	ChatGPT or Gemini, finished in Canva	Images & design
Design a card, flyer or poster	Canva	Images & design
Make a song for an occasion	Suno	Music & voice
Turn writing into a real-sounding voice	ElevenLabs	Music & voice
Tidy spelling, grammar and tone as you type	Grammarly	Productivity
Get notes and a summary from a meeting or call	Otter.ai	Productivity
Build a slide deck or one-pager fast	Gamma	Productivity
Edit a phone or social video	CapCut	Video editing
Make a short video clip from a description	Sora or Veo (still early)	Video

Two questions sharpen the choice:

- **Staying inside an app you already use, or trying a new platform?** If you live in Google, Gemini is the nearest door; in Windows or Office, Copilot. The skills are the same either way.
- **Do you need sources, privacy, or polished design?** Sources, reach for Perplexity or NotebookLM. Privacy, stay with tools whose training toggle you set yourself. Design, Canva.

Step two: start with these first

Twenty tools is a hangar, not a to-do list. Almost everyone’s first few months live in the top tier alone.

Start here first. The six that cover most of ordinary life: ChatGPT · Claude · Gemini · Copilot · Perplexity · Canva

Next, when a job calls for it. Roll these out the day you have the specific need: NotebookLM · Suno · ElevenLabs · Grammarly · Otter.ai · Gamma · CapCut

Specialist, or just so you have heard the name. Optional, niche, or moving too fast to settle: Midjourney · Adobe Firefly · Sora · Google Veo · Grok · DeepSeek · Meta AI

If you only ever fly the first tier, you have not missed a thing. The hangar keeps.

Step three: the aircraft cards

Every card is the same shape: the job it does, who it suits, the one thing to watch, and where the full lesson lives. Read only the cards you are actually heading for.

A note on the lesson pointers. Tools marked **Full lesson** get their own First Flight, start to finish. Tools marked **Spotlight** get a shorter demo lesson.

Tools marked **Awareness only** are here so no name can make you feel behind; they move too fast for an evergreen lesson, so they live in your quarterly updates instead.

Hangar 1 · Chat assistants (your core crew)

Maintenance note: these four are the most stable aircraft in the building. Names and buttons may shift; the brief-steer-verify-decide loop does not.

ChatGPT (OpenAI) · *Best starter* - Job: the all-rounder. Writing, explaining, planning, summarising, thinking out loud. - Best for you if: you want one tool to start with and the most-discussed name in the fleet. - Watch out: sounds certain even when guessing. Verify anything that matters. - → Full lesson: ChatGPT First Flight.

Claude (Anthropic) · *Best for writing and long documents* - Job: natural, careful writing that sounds like you, and calm work through long material. - Best for you if: your jobs are mainly writing, editing and thinking something through. - Watch out: still not a live search engine. Check recent facts. - → Full lesson: Claude First Flight.

Google Gemini · *Best if you live in Google* - Job: everyday help that sits close to Gmail, Docs and Android. - Best for you if: your life already runs on Google. - Watch out: decide what you let it see across your Google account. Verify facts and prices. - → Full lesson: Gemini First Flight.

Microsoft Copilot · *Best if you live in Windows or Office* - Job: help right inside Word, Excel and Outlook, and on Windows. - Best for you if: your day runs on Microsoft apps. - Watch out: the deep Office features are a paid add-on; the chat is free. Know which you are using. - → Full lesson: Copilot First Flight.

Hangar 2 · Research and search (tools that show their sources)

Maintenance note: a citation is a pointer, not a proof. Click one source before you act. The rule of two has simply been handed better paperwork.

Perplexity · *Research specialist* - Job: answers your question in plain English and shows the sources as it goes. - Best for you if: you need an answer you will repeat to another adult, with receipts attached. - Watch out: read the sources, do not just trust the summary. A thin source still gets a tidy number. - → Full lesson: Perplexity First Flight.

NotebookLM (Google) · *Use with your own documents* - Job: answers only from the files you give it, and points to the exact spot. - Best for you if: you have a pile of your own paperwork to understand (policies, manuals, notes). - Watch out: upload only what you are comfortable putting into Google. It still helps to read the cited line. - → Full lesson: NotebookLM First Flight.

Hangar 3 · Images and design

Maintenance note: describing skill is the whole game, and you trained it in Module 2. The first image is always a first draft.

Canva · *Best starter for design* - Job: cards, flyers, posters and tidy documents, laid out for you, with AI woven through. - Best for you if: you want something that looks good without being a designer. - Watch out: friendly and safe; the real risk is losing an afternoon. Upgrade prompts are persistent. - → Full lesson: Canva First Flight.

Midjourney · *Spotlight · the artists' choice* - Job: striking, artistic images from a written description. - Best for you if: you have caught the art bug and want the best-looking results. - Watch out: paid only, runs through Discord or its site, and has a real learning curve. Try Canva or ChatGPT images first. - → Spotlight lesson: Midjourney.

Adobe Firefly · *Spotlight · commercially safer images* - Job: create and edit images trained on licensed content, plus tidy photo edits. - Best for you if: "safe to use commercially" matters to you. - Watch out: "safer" is not "guaranteed". For anything you will sell, check the current terms. - → Spotlight lesson: Firefly.

Hangar 4 · Music and voice

Maintenance note: name the style and era you actually like, and you are most of the way there.

Suno · *Use with nothing personal aboard if sharing publicly* - Job: writes and performs a complete song, words and music, from a short description. - Best for you if: you want a personalised song for a birthday, anniversary or farewell. - Watch out: if you will share it publicly, check the ownership rules for your plan. - → Full lesson: Suno First Flight.

ElevenLabs · *Use with consent only* - Job: turns writing into very natural-sounding speech, in many voices. - Best for you if: you want to narrate a memoir, a chapter or a slideshow. - Watch out: voice cloning is the scam-call technology from Module 5. Clone only your own voice, or one you have clear permission to use. - → Full lesson: ElevenLabs First Flight.

Hangar 5 · Everyday productivity (the quiet workhorses)

Maintenance note: less flashy, more useful week to week. These tend to read what you type, so mind sensitive text.

Grammarly · *Spotlight · tidies as you type* - Job: checks spelling, grammar and tone live, with AI help to rewrite. - Best for you if: you want your everyday writing tidied where you already work. - Watch out: take its suggestions as offers, not orders. Keep the words that sound like you. - → Spotlight lesson: Grammarly.

Otter.ai · *Spotlight · notes you do not have to take* - Job: listens to a meeting or call and writes the transcript and summary. - Best for you if: you want the key points and actions without scribbling. - Watch out: always tell people they are being recorded. It is polite, and often the law. - → Spotlight lesson: Otter.ai.

Gamma · *Spotlight · a deck in minutes* - Job: builds a slide deck, document or one-pager from a short prompt or your notes. - Best for you if: you want a strong first draft of a talk, fast. - Watch out: check every fact and figure it adds. The design is easy; the accuracy is yours. - → Spotlight lesson: Gamma.

Hangar 6 · Video editing

Maintenance note: built for quick, friendly video, mostly on a phone.

CapCut · *Full lesson · everyday video* - Job: trimming, auto-captions, music and effects for family or social video. - Best for you if: you want simple edits without professional software. - Watch out: owned by the same company as TikTok. Read the permissions it asks of your phone. - → Full lesson: CapCut First Flight.

Hangar 7 · The fast-moving and the just-so-you-know

Maintenance note: these change too quickly, or sit too far from this audience, to teach as evergreen lessons. They live in your quarterly updates. None of them can make you behind.

Sora (OpenAI) and **Google Veo** · *Awareness only · video from a sentence* - Job: short video clips from a written description. Remarkable, and improving fast. - Best for you if: you fancy a creative experiment, not a reliable everyday tool. - Watch out: realistic AI video is how fakes are made. Be sceptical, and label your own. - → Awareness only. Covered in your quarterly updates; have a look at one of your check-ins.

Grok (xAI) · *Awareness only · the X assistant* - Job: a cheekier chat assistant inside X, with access to live posts. - Best for you if: you already use X and want a conversational lookup. - Watch out: the least cautious of the fleet by design. Treat everything as a lead to check. - → Awareness only. The same five-minute checklist applies.

DeepSeek · *Awareness only · nothing personal aboard* - Job: a capable free chat tool, strong at reasoning, that made headlines for its cost. - Best for you if: you want a free second opinion on a general question. - Watch out: weaker privacy controls and servers based in China. Recipes and trivia, yes; your life, no. - → Awareness only. Apply the nothing-personal rule.

Meta AI · *Awareness only · inside your social apps* - Job: quick lookups inside WhatsApp, Facebook, Instagram and Messenger. - Best for you if: you want a fast answer without leaving a chat. - Watch out: you never set its privacy toggles. Treat it like chatting at a barbecue, nothing personal. - → Awareness only. Know which assistant you are talking to before you share.

One last thing before you fly

When a new tool appears next month, and one will, do not panic and do not rush to pay. Run the five-minute checklist from Module 1: what job is it for, is the free version enough, what does it want access to, and does it pass the rule of two. Then come back here, slot it into the right hangar, and decide whether it earns a first flight. The tools will keep changing. The way you size them up will not.

For the deeper map of what each hangar is for, see the companion piece, **The Tool Hangar Guide**. This page tells you which aircraft to roll out; the Guide explains the whole building.

Cleared For Take-Off Academy · Naomi Shiels · Wild Hearts Publishing · 2026